



Shelter Inspection Report

Division of Policy and Planning
Office of Continuous Quality Improvement & Evaluation
May 24, 2016

Shelter: [REDACTED]
Provider: [REDACTED]
Location: [REDACTED]
Shelter Type: Adult/Women
Capacity/Census 80/79
Inspection Date: 05/24/16
Inspection Type: Unannounced Observation

The CQI team conducted a site visit on 5/24/16 at 10:55AM. The visit lasted two hours. Contract provider [REDACTED] operates the site. The inspection consisted of a conversation with the Program Director, [REDACTED] and Operations Manager, [REDACTED]. Additional information was provided by social workers [REDACTED] and [REDACTED]. The site tour was facilitated by REMOVED. The following observations were made:

Safety

The CQI team was asked by the [REDACTED] security guard, located in the basement, to show our ID badges. The guard wrote down the CQI team members' names in a logbook. The CQI team proceeded to take the elevator to the fourth floor. On the fourth floor the guard, located at the front desk, asked the CQI team to sign in. [REDACTED] security is contracted by [REDACTED]. The operations manager then took the CQI team's IDs and made copies then returned the IDs.

There is one security guard at the basement desk and one security guard at the fourth floor desk each shift. The security guard shifts are 7AM-3PM, 3PM-11PM, and 11PM-7AM. Security conducts rounds every half hour. During the rounds, security visits the dorms, community room, kitchen, and lounge area. Security also ensures that the storage room is closed, inspects the bathroom area, laundry room, back stairwell and makes sure all doors are locked or open if necessary. There are 15 working security cameras and one security camera that is out of service.

As part of the site's intake procedure, new clients have their belongings screened for weapons before they are allowed to enter the shelter. The security guards have security wands, but the wands are only used when there is cause or suspicion of a client harboring a weapon. Locker searches occur regularly and randomly in addition to suspicious locker searches. Clients sneaking food into the shelter appears to be the most significant concern of the security team. Every bag is checked when clients get off the elevator in addition to checking their pockets.



Fire drills occur three times per month—once during each shift. There is a handicap list that has all immobile clients on it. There is a designated area where disabled clients are expected to wait in the event of an emergency.

██████ does not have a fire panel but does have an active fire safety plan. The ██████ handles the fire panel. ██████ has a fire safety coordinator. Each dorm has a smoke/carbon alarm. The fire extinguisher observed was last serviced June 2015 and there is a fire hose in the main hallway.

██████ evacuation plans are viewable next to the elevator and exits. Approximately 95% of staff at the front desk have a fireguard certificate.

If there is an Incident onsite the protocol is to contact EMS or NYPD and write up a report. As of recent ██████ "have been doing better lately.", only two to three incidents per week. Most of those incidents are medical. If a client falls, the client is required to be medically cleared prior to returning to ██████.

Staffing

In total there are 29 staff members at ██████: Shelter Director (Monday-Friday 9AM-5PM), Director of Social Services (varying schedule ranging from Monday –Saturday 9AM-8PM), two social workers—one of whom is bilingual (Spanish) (varying schedule ranging from Monday –Saturday 7AM-7PM), Director of Housing and Placement (Monday-Friday 9AM-5PM), two Housing Specialist (varying schedule ranging from Monday-Friday 8AM-5PM), Social Services Manager and six Social Services Workers (varying schedule ranging from Sunday-Sunday 7AM-12AM), Director of Operations (Sunday-Thursday 7AM 3PM), six Case Managers (varying schedule ranging from Sunday-Sunday 7AM-11PM).

There are four maintenance workers (varying schedule Maintenance Hours: 5:00AM-1:00PM, 10:00AM 2:00PM, 11:00AM-8:00PM, and 12:00AM-5:00AM. There is no maintenance from 8PM-12AM and only two maintenance workers during the weekend.

Facility Conditions

The entrance to ██████ is located on ██████ street. It is a side entrance to the building through the basement. Clients have access to various storage areas in the basement of the building. The CQI team initially walked into the wrong section of the basement until a utility worker directed the CQI team to the security desk. Notice of Disability Rights posted in basement.

The elevator used to go up to the shelter is a freight elevator with padded walls. The operations director noted that a new elevator shaft was being installed. Loud drilling during the CQI visit was heard. Plasterboard wall built around the construction of a new shaft.

The CQI team spoke with the operations manager and shelter director in the staff lounge. The lounge contained the following: table, seven chairs, refrigerator, microwave, toaster, garbage can, file cabinets, bulletin board with SEIU 1199 information and OSHA laws postings.

The entire shelter is on one floor. On the east end of the floor the staff lounge is located in the back of the housing specialist offices. Opposite the housing specialist offices are the social services offices.



Working west on the floor one would see: a stairwell, the front desk, mailboxes, dorms A-F (each dorm holds 13-15 clients), computer area, bathrooms, nurses office, laundry room, dining area with TV (used for Spanish TV), community room, piano, books, lounge, the operations manager's office, and two sets of emergency exits – one on each side and alarmed if opened.

Shelter repair flier posted in both Spanish and English. Bathroom signs state that the bathroom is closed for cleaning at 11:30AM and again at 5:30PM. Bathrooms were just cleaned when CQI arrived. There are eight toilet stalls, eight sinks and mirrors, and nine shower stalls that are elevated by one step. There is one handicapped accessible stall. Stalls appeared very clean and well maintained.

The laundry room has four dryers and three washers. The nurse's office is across from the laundry room. A little further down from the nurse's office is a lounge area in the hallway as well as the operations manager's office.

The cafeteria has a serving station and there are seven tables. The second room (community room) has six tables. Walls appear to be made of wood, the doors appear to be made of stained glass and wood. The linen closet is located at the end of the hall and the storage room is located behind the hallway door next to the bathrooms.

Dorm E contained the following: mid-level metal walls and lockers, shades, ceiling windows, cubby-like area for each client with twin bed and locker. No smoking sign, strobe fire alarm, and numerous electrical sockets above locker height built into walls. Sky lights, clean floors, room temp set to 72 degrees.

Shelter Process

The process of new clients arriving at [REDACTED] is as follows: [REDACTED] contacts Vacancy Control (IVC) at 10:30PM, 12:30AM, and 2AM. Each call to IVC provides IVC with an updated census. If there is a vacancy IVC assigns a client to [REDACTED]. [REDACTED] target demographic are women that are age 45 or older. [REDACTED] only house women outside of that demographic when DHS needs a bed for a night for a potential client that is being processed for shelter or if DHS cannot find another shelter to house a younger female client.

Clients may arrive on a DHS provided bus or via their own mode of transportation. [REDACTED] staff meets the client(s) at the basement entrance. CARES is checked to ensure clients are assigned to [REDACTED]. Social Services checks email to see if there are any notices about clients. Clients are screened at the front desk in the basement then are brought upstairs where intake begins in one of the offices.

Initial intake is conducted, all belongings are washed, clients have to take a shower and wash the clothes

they are wearing. Clients receive shampoo, conditioner, brushes, combs, razors, and robes. Linen is provided every week on Saturday or as needed.



If clients arrive during the late night then their items are put into storage. But clients have to shower. If they do not comply, then clients are not allowed into the dorms. The dorms are closed from 9:30AM 1PM.

Meals are served at the following times: breakfast at 7:15AM-8AM, 12PM-12:45PM, 5:30PM-6:15AM. Meals are prepared at [REDACTED] and maintenance brings it over and serves it.

Basement entrance is open between 7AM-8PM, the main entrance to the [REDACTED] is open between 5AM-7AM. The main entrance has a security guard on duty at the front desk 24 hours a day. The main entrance is access controlled overnight. The security guard station there will open the door if someone knocks.

[REDACTED] works with Project Renewal, a local health provider. Project Renewal has a nurse and nurse practitioner onsite twice a week. The nurse is onsite Mondays to Thursdays from 12:30PM-5:30PM. The nurse practitioner is onsite on Tuesdays and Thursdays from 11AM-6PM. A psychiatrist is onsite on Mondays and Wednesdays from 7AM-3PM and Wednesday 12PM-6PM. [REDACTED] is in the process of hiring a full time psychiatrist. Medical administration occurs onsite. The nurse sits with the clients and puts the pills in the pillboxes. If the nurse is not onsite one day, staff can go with clients to get pillboxes. There are currently 10 clients signed up for medical monitoring.

Everyday except Sundays staff goes to the mailroom in the armory and brings it up to [REDACTED] and then Steve, from the housing team, forwards the mail of clients that are no longer onsite to the address they currently have. This process is completed no later than 6:30PM.

Visitors are not allowed in the shelter. All clients and visitors to [REDACTED] are required to sign in upon arrival. Additionally clients are expected to sign out as well. Curfew is at 10PM and the DHS Nightly Roster printed at 8:30PM and placed at the front desk at 9PM.

Money management takes place onsite in the form of money orders that are kept in a safe onsite. The money orders are placed in an envelope that has the client's name on it. Additionally, if clients would like to store important documents like a passport or social security card, the client's social worker would accommodate that request.

The [REDACTED] and [REDACTED], the Program Administrator and Program Analyst respectively, are stated as being very helpful.

Groups and game days are available seven days a week. Some of the activities include artwork,

community meeting, stress management, women's health group, life after homelessness, mindful meditation, life sharing, movie night, karaoke. "Linen Exchange @ Linen Closet" is also listed on the event calendar. Clients also have computer access and access to laundry room—both free of charge.



There are several undocumented clients onsite. One undocumented client AWOL after 48 hours of not signing the DHS Nightly Roster and not returning to the site; currently there are three other undocumented clients. For one of the undocumented clients [REDACTED] staff has escorted the client to their embassy to make sure they have proper documentation. Clients are also connected to free immigration lawyers when possible.

Some of the clients at [REDACTED] are employed. For those clients returning to site after meal times, dinner is stored for them. The working clients notify social service of their expected arrival time and social services notify the kitchen staff to save the meal. There are internship programs available for clients to develop skills. Clients can be cooks at other shelters or deliver food to other shelters in the Lenox Hill Neighborhood House portfolio.

The following are barriers the staff encounter when attempting to place clients into housing: translating services for clients that do not speak English—staff currently speak Mandarin, Spanish, and sign language; high caseworker to caseload ratio (approximately 26 cases per case worker), clients without proper documentation or undocumented clients, clients that do not have enough money saved, not enough supporting housing available—this is particularly important because [REDACTED] focuses mostly on supportive housing, clients lacking insight into mental illness or disagreeing with diagnoses, clients that may not apply for income, clients that do not interview well. The target placement for clients is approximately 15 clients per quarter.

Based on observations made during the site visit, the following recommendations have been determined:

- Meal times longer than 45 minutes (Best Practice: 1 Hour);
- Main entrance of Park Avenue Armory should be the only non-emergency entrance into the shelter;
- Consistently use metal detecting security wand when clients enter the shelter • Mandatory shower should not be a prerequisite for new clients seeking shelter (491.7(d)(13)); • Hire a sufficient number of caseworkers to reduce caseworker to caseload ratio (491.8(b));

Part 491 violations finding:

- 491.7(d)(13)
"A resident shall not be obliged to perform work by coercion or threat."
- 491.8(b)

“An operator who proposes to serve a population with particular needs, e.g., the aged, substance abusers, alcoholics or alcohol abusers, ex-offenders, or the mentally or physically disabled, shall demonstrate that cooperative arrangements have been made with appropriate providers of funding or services and that a program of service and staff sufficient to meet the needs of the population.”